three weeks, followed by an exam on it, which turned out to be more difficult than the one at AFA in the previous term. A helicopter checklist is exhaustive and has a plethora of contents to learn. After this test, which came almost a month after joining the school, all the cadets were allotted instructors. I was allotted Chief Flying Instructor Wing Commander R.O.J. Assey and was his only pupil. He had recently been posted at HTS but hadn't yet joined.

As we had heard from our seniors, the start-up procedure in a helicopter was the most difficult part to learn. While other cadets had begun their training, I was waiting for the CFI to join HTS. When Anuradha would come back and tell me about how tough the start-up procedure was to understand and learn, I would worry, knowing that I was losing out while the others were learning.

I thought of seeking help and walked up to Anuradha's instructor one day. 'Who is your instructor?' he asked me. When I told him my instructor was Wing Commander Assey, he replied, 'Oh, Assey Sir? I think he should be the one to teach you about the start-up procedure, not me.' I wondered why the mention of my instructor had evoked such a reaction in him.

Anuradha advised me to speak to the flight commander who was second-in-command under the CFI. The response I received from him was no different from the last. It left me even more confused. It was after the gossip reached the other cadets that I learnt that Wing Commander Assey had the reputation of being a hard taskmaster and was known to be strict and thorough, someone who always went by the book. Why nobody wanted to teach me was because if they demonstrated anything slightly wrong to me and if the CFI later learnt about it, he would give them a hard time. Fifteen days went by and I finally knocked on the CFI's door upon his arrival. When I stepped inside, I saw in front of me a six-foot-tall, broad-built man. He was pacing up and down in his office with a bunch of documents in his hands.

'What do you want?' he asked without looking up.

'Sir, I'm your pupil, Flight Cadet Gunjan Saxena,' I answered, trying hard to sound confident.